

Two-Stage Electoral Process for Electing Local Spiritual Assemblies

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THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

16 January 2020

The National Spiritual Assembly of the Bahá'ís of India

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

You will no doubt recall that in its letter of 27 December 2005 to the Conference of the Continental Boards of Counsellors, the Universal House of Justice anticipated the establishment of a two-stage electoral process for the election of Local Spiritual Assemblies in certain local communities where the size of the Bahá'í population and other circumstances would warrant this development. Indeed, such a two-stage election had its historical precedent in the system established at 'Abdu'l-Bahá's direction for the election of the Local Spiritual Assembly of Tíhrán. The introduction of this approach in the context of communities that are experiencing significant growth will, it is hoped, provide a means by which believers, especially those newly enrolled, can be more effectively connected to administrative processes within the community in general, and to their Local Assembly in particular.

The House of Justice has been following with great interest the steady acceleration of the process of growth in your country, and it feels that in a number of communities in India it would now be possible to institute a two-stage election of Local Assemblies. However, in order to allow for the necessary experience to emerge gradually, the House of Justice has decided that the first efforts would start, at Ridván 2020, in only two local communities, Delhi and Hathwan Panchayat. In this way, lessons learned in both an urban and a rural setting will facilitate the future introduction of this approach more widely in India, and indeed elsewhere in the world. You are asked to now begin, in close consultation with the Counsellors and with the help of the State Bahá'í Council of Bihar and the Regional Bahá'í Council of Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand and Delhi, to prepare these two communities for this development.

The election of a Local Spiritual Assembly using a two-stage process will be conducted in a manner similar to that of a National Spiritual Assembly, that is, the believers in a designated unit will elect delegates who, in turn, will elect members of the Local Assembly from among all the adult believers in the entire locality. For now, the number of delegates will be 19, which would be assigned in proportion to the adult Bahá'í membership of each unit. In Delhi, the city should be divided into electoral units, preferably in a way that would allow two delegates to be assigned to each, wherever this is possible. In Hathwan Panchayat, the village should be the primary basis upon which units are decided. A village with a sufficient number of adult Bahá'ís to elect at least one delegate would be one unit. However, in some cases you might deem it necessary to combine two or more nearby villages with very small Bahá'í populations to form a unit. A village with a very large Bahá'í population may need to be divided into multiple units; as in Delhi, each such unit would preferably be assigned two delegates. In the latter case, as far as possible, the units may follow naturally existing sections of the village.

The election of the delegates can take place in the days preceding Ridván, starting from the first day of the month of Jalál, and the believers would be invited to attend a unit gathering to vote for the number of delegates assigned, from among the adult believers who reside in the unit. Drawing on the relevant Bahá'í

principles and existing practices, and depending on circumstances, your Assembly, in consultation with the Counsellors, can decide the manner of conducting these unit gatherings, including such details as how absentee ballots are treated, how ballots are counted, how ties are broken, how the result of the voting in each unit is announced, how delegates are informed of the process by which they will elect the Local Spiritual Assembly, and how results are announced to the whole community. An important determination with regard to the voting by the delegates is whether they will send their ballots to a place or person designated by the Local Assembly, or whether it would be preferable for them to gather in one place to discharge their spiritual prerogative. Should you decide that the holding of a gathering would be advantageous, it is of paramount importance to ensure that a spiritual atmosphere prevails throughout the course of the event; however, there would be no need to have consultative sessions, such as those that take place during the National Convention. Whatever procedures are put in place, the entire process should be completed by the first day of Riḍván, at which time an announcement would be made to the community of the nine believers elected to the Local Assembly.

Beyond assisting the friends in the community to become familiar with the various procedural aspects of a two-stage election, you will no doubt wish to give thought as to how they can be helped to develop a deep appreciation for those spiritual imperatives that characterize Bahá'í elections. For many new believers, their understanding of the word "election" derives from the political elections that take place in the country, and the various ideas and practices associated with them, most of which are, in profound ways, at variance with the Bahá'í approach. The movement of populations towards Bahá'u'lláh's vision of a New World Order demands a major shift in how the believers view authority within the community and how those who will exercise this authority are chosen. A point of departure is the fact that the believers do not seek positions on an institution by putting themselves forward and attempting to solicit votes; rather, free from any trace of ambition, they understand election to such a role as a call to service. Taking active part in the life of the community throughout the year, they use every opportunity to become thoroughly acquainted with one another; thus they are able to consider prayerfully the range of believers for whom they can vote, and then select those who best combine the necessary qualities. Other important factors, such as age distribution, diversity, and gender, also need due consideration, so that the membership of the Assembly will be representative of the choicest and most varied and capable elements of the community. As the believers are assisted to develop a more profound understanding of Bahá'í elections, they will, when the time comes for them to vote at both stages, approach this duty in a prayerful attitude, seeking divine guidance and confirmation. As Shoghi Effendi has advised, "they must turn completely to God, and with a purity of motive, a freedom of spirit and a sanctity of heart, participate in the elections."

Following the elections, the House of Justice would appreciate receiving from you a report on the details of procedures instituted and any comments on the conduct of the elections in these two localities. You are encouraged to consult with the Counsellors in the preparation of this report.

As you embark on this significant enterprise, you may be assured of the prayers of the House of Justice in the Holy Shrines on your behalf, that Bahá'u'lláh may guide your steps and ever sustain you in your devoted labours for His Cause.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]